

Central and South America

Windsor Caves

Location Jamaica, Caribbean Sea

These are some of the biggest underground caverns of the forested limestone hills of Jamaica’s Cockpit Country. “Cockpits” refer to the steep-sided depressions up to 330 ft (100m) deep that dominate the landscape of this area. Thick layers of the White Limestone Formation have been weathered and eroded by the action of rainwater and groundwater to form underground caverns and

other karst features. Windsor Great Cave is 2 miles (3 km) long and has an underground river, stalactites, stalagmites, and some beautiful roof scalloping. It also has a high-level remnant of an ancient drainage system, now largely choked with calcite deposits, and houses the island’s largest bat roost.

▼ THE LONG DROP OF KAIETEUR FALLS

Lake Nicaragua

Location The Pacific Coast of Nicaragua

Along with its neighbor, Lake Managua, this giant freshwater lake formed in a part of the bottom of a graben—a faulted section of crust that slipped down between the land on either side. Lake Nicaragua is the largest lake in Central America, 110 miles (177 km) long and 36 miles (58 km) wide. Although only a thin strip of land separates it from the Pacific Ocean, the San Juan River drains the lake into the far more distant Caribbean Sea.

The Orinoco

Location Venezuela and Colombia, from the Guiana Highlands to the Atlantic Ocean

Along with the Amazon, the Paraná, and the Tocantins, the Orinoco is one of the four great rivers of South America. It rises in the forested Guiana Highlands and flows through them in a great arc before crossing the seasonally flooded plains of the Llanos. Finally, it splits into many distributaries in a vast delta, its waters reaching the Atlantic Ocean 1,700 miles (2,740 km) from its source. The Orinoco’s basin incorporates 80 percent of Venezuela and 25 percent of Colombia. The river’s rate of flow varies dramatically—at Ciudad Bolívar, for example, its depth varies from 50 to 165 ft (15 to 50 m) according to the season.

Kaieteur Falls

Location Mazaruni-Potaro Shield, Guyana

A combination of height, width, and water volume makes Kaieteur one of the world’s largest single-drop waterfalls. In the pristine rain forest of the Guiana Highlands, the Potaro

